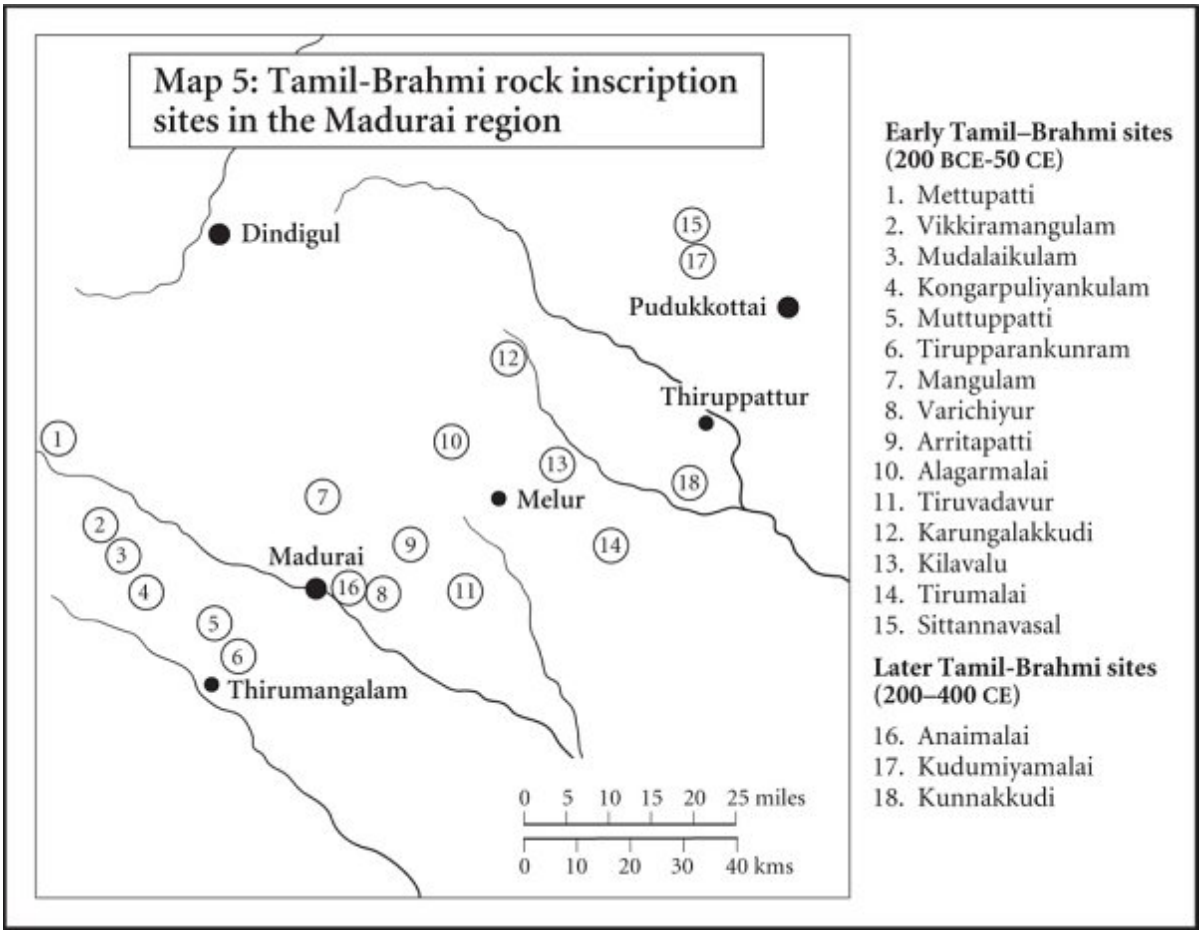
now suggested a very early dating, with the royal patron in question most likely being Yanaikatcei Mandaran Irumporai, an ally of the Cheras captured in battle by the Pandyas and taken as a prisoner to Madurai.



Early Tamil-Brahmi inscription sites in the Madurai region, all associated with Jain retreats in caves or rock-shelters.

In that same year of 1965 Mahadevan began to re-examine all the known cave inscriptions in the Madurai area, beginning at Alagarmalai, another imposing rock just east of Madurai (see Map 5). Here there were no fewer than thirteen of what were now recognised as Tamil-Brahmi inscriptions, carved on the brow of one large cave at the foot of the hill. The script was more evolved than at Pugalur, pointing to a later date, but all the inscriptions recorded the